

Foreword by Bettina L. Love

To know Gholdy Muhammad is to know love. To see her teach is to witness what the great Dr. Asa Hillard called a Master Teacher. To hear her lecture, you quickly realize she is unmatched in her ability to articulate why literacy is important beyond the surface of learning how to read and write, as a necessary tool for justice, equity, and a world where the humanity and dignity of those pushed to the edges of society are front and center. She embodies this work, and I am forever grateful to know that she is among the amazing folks fighting for the lives of Black and Brown children to matter.

This book is simply brilliant. It is Gholdy's literacy love letter for helping teachers cultivate the genius of Black and Brown children. What she has written is a way to see literacy through a framework that does not run from our current political times and embraces both the diversity of learning and the diversity



of our children, all while doing the work of connecting children to who they are. You must know who you are and why you are important to this world, and learn how to be you. And this is particularly true for our Black and Brown children—because this world will constantly tell you that you are not good enough based on the color of your skin.

Gholdy's four-layered Historically Responsive Literacy framework includes identity development, skill development, intellectual development, and criticality. This equity framework uses literacy to make our children whole. Black folx and folx of color in this country have always used language, guided by history, to resist, because we understand that our rights and our dignity are tightly knitted together to our history and language.

This book is written in the tradition of Ella Baker, Ida B. Wells, bell hooks, Gloria Anzaldúa, Angela Davis, and Cherrie Moraga. Those women knew that fighting for justice in solidarity with each other is a beautiful struggle, and that words must be the foundation. In education, we have allowed terms like “at risk,” “disadvantaged,” and “struggling reader” to define our children, never considering that those terms have a history, too. As Gholdy points out, this deficit language that frames Black and Brown children's educational experience is rooted in and guided by Whiteness. It is precisely for that reason that strategies like

“racing to the top” and “leaving no child behind” always fail because we are not teaching to repair and make our children feel whole and loved through their own identities, skills, intellect, and criticality.

There are many paths to a liberating education. *Cultivating Genius* is one that is needed both before and after liberation. Gholdy’s groundbreaking book provides urgent pedagogy for urgent times. Gholdy placed love at the center of her method for teaching students, and you will, in turn, love this book and its message that meaning-making of children’s stories is the way to humanize ourselves, which must happen before we enter the classroom.

Gholdy has written the new blueprint for how we teach responsive literacy. The Black Literary Societies of the 1800s, of which she so eloquently writes, would be proud. She has picked up the legacy and is running toward freedom. We in education need to follow and run with her.



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I conceive our Literary Institutions to have the power of doing. It seems to me, then, that the main object is to accomplish an intellectual and moral reformation. And I know of but few better ways to effect this than by reading, by examining, by close comparisons and thorough investigations, by exercising the great faculty of thinking; for, if a man can be brought to think, he soon discovers that his highest enjoyment consists in the improvement of the mind; it is this that will give him rich ideas, and teach him, also, that his limbs were never made to wear the chains of servitude; he will see too that equal rights were intended to all. Then who would not wish to become inspired with the taste of reading, if it has the ability to create so happy a state of things as I have just described.

—James Forten in an address delivered before the American Moral Reform Society, August 17, 1837

Throughout the 1800s, a central objective among Black people was to improve and elevate their lives through literary means. One of the ways in which they set out to counter the conditions they endured during a time of racism and oppression was through reading, writing, and engaging with literary texts. As part of a broader struggle to counter multiple attacks of oppression with violence, they used their minds

and pens as weapons to battle injustice. Books and other forms of texts became ammunition to fuel their progress. They worked toward cultivating the minds and hearts within themselves and among others, which led them to being equipped to face and alter the nation's harshest realities. Literacy was no longer just a set of skills to possess, but the instruments used to define their lives and the tools to advocate for their rights. To this end, Black people developed literary societies or "literary institutions," which were essentially collaborative teaching and learning spaces to construct knowledge and engage one another toward cultivating a literary culture.



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This cultivation of literacy and the genius inside these societies perhaps is best exemplified by an excerpt from an 1837 public speech delivered by James Forten (excerpted at left). Forten, a leading thinker, businessman, and social activist, spoke of literary societies in this address. Literary societies were organized

reading and writing groups for developing literacy skills, but they also helped members to read, write, and think in ways that would help foster a better humanity for all. These groups were organized as early as 1828 in cities within the northeast region of the United States. These societies existed in major cities such as Philadelphia, New York, and Boston. Black people created their own spaces because they were not invited or allowed to speak or participate in White-run literary organizations. Soon after 1828, other societies spread across the geographic area and developed in cities such as Pittsburgh; Hartford; Washington, D.C.; Rochester; and Baltimore. They met regularly in person to discuss literature and to debate. They also communicated with each other and across cities through the use of their pens. Newspapers, pamphlets, and other publications were useful ways to send messages about progress, news of the social times, and updates on their activities. Members paid dues to the societies that went into the cultivation and purchase of books for their libraries. Typically, there were fewer than 10 members who founded individual organizations, but membership in some groups grew to over 100 people.

Forten's first line in his speech emphasizes that literacy has the power of doing. Literacy is not just about reading words on the page; it also carries some sort of action. In other words, reading and writing are transformative acts that improve self and soci-

ety. In his speech, Forten called attention to the importance of being able to read, to investigate text, and to teach that no one was created to wear chains of servitude and oppression. He professes that literacy is not just something one attains, but that it is, indeed, a human right.



In contrast to what is currently found in many schools and classrooms, the historical roots of literacy learning in Black communities were much more expansive and advanced and included the goals of identity meaning-making and criticality. In contemporary classrooms across the nation, teachers, school

leaders, and teacher educators are still wrestling with ways to improve and elevate the literacy achievement of youth, especially Black children and other culturally and linguistically diverse populations. Alas, we are underserving large populations of students who are in dire need of excellence, brilliance, and teachers who make it impossible for them to fail. Consider the stagnant achievement over the past 25 years—the result of an overemphasis on skills and drills. Current policies and learning standards that govern schools (such as the Common Core State Standards) are focused primarily on skills and knowledge. We must ask ourselves:

- What is missing from the ways we structure education today?
- Why have school leaders and policy makers been unable to accelerate learning at a greater pace with the standards and pedagogies that have traditionally been taught in schools?
- What is absent from the curricular standards and frameworks that are needed for the holistic development and robust literacy achievement for our children?
- What can we learn from history (particularly Black excellence) to refashion curriculum and instruction today? (Black excellence includes the outstanding attributes and contributions of Black people throughout time and

currently, but sadly it is rarely taught in K–12 schools or teacher education programs.)

- Why are school leaders still mandating curricular frameworks that were not explicitly designed for students of color?

If we aim to get it right with all youth, a productive starting point is to design teaching and learning to the group(s) of students who have been marginalized the most in society and within schools. Thus, we need frameworks that have been written by people of color and designed *for* children of color. *Cultivating Genius* provides such a framework.



The model and content of this book puts critical theory, sociocultural theory, and cognitive theories collectively into a practical model for teaching and learning—one that helps youth develop both personally and academically.

In this book, I argue for a reframed set of learning standards in literacy education—one that is grounded in history and

that restores excellence in education. These historical learning standards (defined within Historically Responsive Literacy) allow educators to reimagine what learning can look like and begin to offer a promising framework for students who have not traditionally seen themselves in formal learning situations. The framework offered here allows for a practical model based on culturally relevant and responsive theories of education. Further, the model and content of this book puts critical theory, sociocultural theory, and cognitive theories collectively into a practical model for teaching and learning—one that helps youth develop both personally and academically.

From my lenses as a teacher, scholar, school board member, researcher, and teacher educator, I have come to learn that there is much that we can do to improve how literacy education is framed today. In my historical research, I discovered that the ways in which literacy was conceptualized and practiced throughout the 19th century among Black populations were more advanced and, compared to how we engage youth today, more challenging and intellectually invigorating. I sought to understand the lessons educators could learn from our history to then return to this excellence for the sake of our students, teachers, families, and communities. This book was especially written to support those students for whom the educational system was not designed—namely, Black and Brown students.

This is the group of students who are most consistently being underserved. My historical inquiry led me to a set of new learning standards to frame goals for literacy education—one that I argue is needed for the current political times and diverse populations of schools. In this book, I share the ways in which literacy was defined historically and offer a four-layered equity framework for reimagining the standards we set for teaching and learning. This practical framework is useful for designing literacy instruction and education across all content areas.



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The four-layered equity framework conceptualized here includes the learning goals of 1) identity development; 2) skill development; 3) intellectual development; and 4) criticality. Black people who participated in literary societies in Northeastern cities throughout the 19th century, like the one described by

James Forten, have held these four goals—or learning pursuits—for personal and academic achievement. I use learning goals and pursuits synonymously to denote the aims we should have for learning. These four learning pursuits defined literacy. And because literacy was synonymous with education during that time, it was also how they framed their general learning. Each time early Black readers came together to read, write, think, and learn, they were making sense of who they were (identity), developing their proficiencies in the content they were learning within (skills), becoming smarter about something or gaining new knowledge and concepts in the world (intellect), and finally, developing the ability to read texts (including print texts and social *con-texts*) to understand power, authority and anti-oppression (criticality). The latter goal of criticality is the capacity to read, write, and think in the context of understanding power, privilege, and oppression. Criticality is also related to seeing, naming, and interrogating the world to not only make sense of injustice, but also work toward social transformation. Thus, students need spaces to name and critique injustice to help them ultimately develop the agency to build a better world. As long as oppression is present in the world, young people need pedagogy that nurtures criticality.



With text at the nexus, this framework helps to redesign the ways in which teacher educators engage preservice teachers at the university level as they prepare the next generation of educators who will serve to disrupt racism, sexism, and other oppressions. This book will help educators redesign their learning goals, lesson/unit plans, and importantly, the texts they use to teach. While offering a space for advanced pedagogy that moves beyond cognitive literacies, the ideas in this book incorporate multiple theoretical orientations to teaching and learning,

including cognitive, sociocultural, critical, and sociohistorical theories. Thus, the equity framework discussed in *Cultivating Genius* is named the Historically Responsive Literacy (HRL) Framework, which addresses students' *Identities, Skills, Intellect, and Criticality*. The HRL Framework also responds to the limitations of traditional school curricula, urging us to recognize and embrace the exalted literacy legacy—established by the 19th century Black literary societies—of our students of color.

This historical blueprint is precisely why educators need to move toward *cultivating the genius* that already lies within students and teachers. History from Black communities tells us that educators don't need to empower youth or give them brilliance or genius. Instead, the power and genius is already within them. Genius is the brilliance, intellect, ability, cleverness, and artistry that have been flowing through their minds and spirits across the generations. This cultivation calls for reaching back into students' histories and deeply knowing them and their ancestries to teach in ways that raise, grow, and develop their existing genius. The cultivation of the genius within all of us has been a call throughout history. Alexander Crummell, who was a scholar, teacher, and former Howard University professor, gave a speech entitled *The Attitude of the American Mind Toward the Negro Intellect* [1897]. In the full speech, he noted that those in economic power have never been interested in stimulating

the minds of the Black race, which has left Black people alone in many ways. He argues, however, for Black people to stimulate and cultivate their own minds.

Crummell states:

For the first time in the history of this nation the colored people of America have undertaken the difficult task, of stimulating and fostering the genius of their race as a distinct and definite purpose... To me it is, I confess, a matter of rejoicing that we have, as a people, reached a point where we have a class of men who will come together for purposes, so pure, so elevating, so beneficent, as the cultivation of mind...

This cultivation of the mind or of genius is vital to the success of Black children and, by this model, of all youth.



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In 1837, William Whipper said in a public address, "...as we cultivate our intellectual faculties, we shall strengthen our reasoning powers..." as a goal for education (Woodson, 2015, p. 3).

Not long after, in 1904, Mary Church Terrell wrote about the educational cultivation of Black women and girls and how this effort has yielded academic progress:

When one considers the obstacles encountered by colored women in their effort to educate and cultivate themselves, since they became free, the work they have accomplished and the progress they have made will bear favorable comparison, at least with that of their more fortunate sisters, from whom the opportunity of acquiring knowledge and the means of self-culture have never been entirely withheld (Mullings & Marable, 2009, p. 166).

To teach geniuses, however, charges teachers to cultivate their own genius that lies within them. A friend told me once that teaching should be reserved for the brightest and most brilliant among us. An anonymous sister author wrote to other sisters of the Philadelphia Literary Association in *The Liberator* newspaper on July 7, 1832, "You have talent—only cultivate them; you have minds—enrich them." If we connect this powerful line to the present moment, teachers need to be truth and

knowledge seekers. They must know theory and practice and be masterful with science and the art of pedagogy. African American teacher Prince Saunders supported such efforts in the early 1800s:

Many, in different periods, by cultivating the arts and sciences, have contributed to human happiness and improvement, by that invincible zeal of moral virtue and intellectual excellence, which their example has inspired in other minds and hearts, as well as by the sublimity of those traces of truth with which they have illuminated the world, and dignified the intercourse of civilized society (Porter, 1995, p. 89).

If teachers do not recognize their own genius, they need to be striving each day for it. Mediocrity is not an option. The Historically Responsive Literacy (HRL) Framework is a universal teaching and learning model that helps teachers cultivate the genius within students and within themselves and teach in ways that create spaces for mutual empowerment, confidence, and self-reliance.



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This book is designed for K–12 educators, including teachers, paraprofessionals, and school leaders such as principals, curriculum leaders/writers, and academic coaches. The content in *Cultivating Genius* is also for preservice teachers going into the field and teacher educators as they prepare the next generation of teachers. Finally, it is my hope that those developers and writers behind state standards, district curriculum, and state exams read the four components of the HRL Framework closely as a means to rethink and expand the standards and questions we ask of students.

We have so long prescribed and written what others think is best for youth in schools, all while leaving out of the picture the ways communities of color have historically acquired and used literacy. The culturally and historically responsive literacy framework I offer serves to reorient literacy to our students' lives and asks educators to implement an equity framework that

aligns with and accounts for our rich history and exalted literacy legacy.